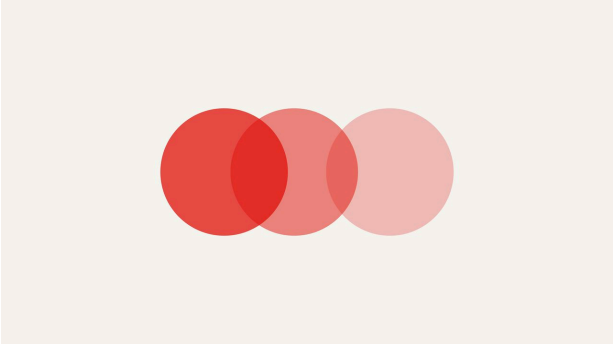
The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Israel's armed forces said troops were "operating in southern Lebanon" as its offensive against **Hizbullah**, an Iran-backed militant group, intensified. Israel's defence minister said soldiers would "advance and seize additional strategic areas" to protect the border. Meanwhile Israel launched a wave of "extensive air strikes" on both Lebanon and Iran. Hizbullah said it had targeted three Israeli military facilities.

Donald Trump vowed retribution for an Iranian drone attack on the American embassy in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia's capital, which caused a fire and structural damage. Earlier he suggested that war with Iran would last "four to five weeks". Six American troops have died so far. At least 787 people have been killed in **Iran**, according to the Iranian Red Crescent Society, a charity.

Oil and natural-gas markets remained volatile after Iran said it had closed the **Strait of Hormuz** and threatened to set any ship that tried to pass through "ablaze". The route carries a third of global seaborne oil. The price of liquefied natural gas soared after QatarEnergy LNG, the world's biggest producer of the fuel, halted production following Iranian drone attacks on its facilities.

Asian **stockmarkets** fell sharply following the attack on America's Riyadh embassy. Earlier American shares recovered slightly from earlier losses, mostly closing flat. Airline stocks bore the brunt of an earlier sell-off, following airspace closures across the Middle East. Defence and energy stocks surged. Gold prices rallied as investors sought a safe haven, while American treasury yields also moved higher as rising oil prices stoked fears of inflation.

Emmanuel Macron said France would increase the size of its nuclear arsenal for the first time in decades, as defence ties with America fray. France is the only nuclear power in the European Union, but the president said he would allow nuclear warheads to be temporarily stationed in allied European countries. This would enable "Europeans to regain control of their own destiny", he added.

Nvidia, a chip giant, said it would invest $2bn each in Lumentum and Coherent, two American companies that develop photonics, a technology used in data-centre fibre optics, among other things. Shares in both companies, whose systems use light to transfer data, rose by more than 10% following the announcement. Nvidia's share price rose by as much as 4.9% on Monday.

The administrator overseeing **Brewdog**, a once-woke, now-broke British brewer, closed 38 of its bars and laid off 484 staff, as it agreed to sell the brand to Tilray, an American beer firm and cannabis producer, for £33m ($44m). Small equity holders, so-called Equity Punks, who invested more than £75m through crowdfunding, will not be compensated. Brewdog at first thrived on its rebellious image, but bosses were later accused of running a toxic work culture.

Figure of the day: 14%, how much more likely it is that a cancer patient will commit a crime in the decade after their diagnosis than someone without cancer, according to a recent study. Read the full story.

Photograph: AP

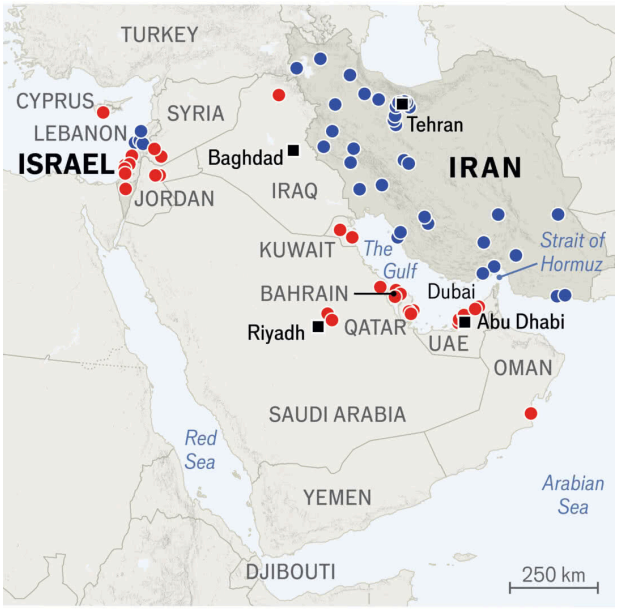
“Horizontal escalation” in the Middle East

The war in Iran is widening. Iran’s retaliation against Gulf Arab states has been faster and more aggressive than many expected, targeting airports and energy infrastructure. Hizbullah, the Lebanese militant group, has fired rockets and drones at northern Israel. And Israel is bombing Beirut, Lebanon’s capital. A suspected Iranian drone struck a British military base in Cyprus. Britain has said America can use its airfields for its war.

How long can this last? Donald Trump has suggested as many as “four to five weeks”. It is not clear who in Iran would be in a position to lead hypothetical negotiations with America, given that 49 of its leaders have been killed. Iran was thought to have enough missiles to sustain its current rate of fire for weeks. Launchers that emerge from hiding, however, will be hunted not just by Israel, as in last year’s conflict, but also by America. “Prepare for many prolonged days of combat,” assesses Eyal Zamir, chief of staff of the Israel Defence Forces.

Reported air strikes, at March 2nd 18:30 GMT

● United States and Israel ● Iran



Sources: Liveuamap.com; press reports

Photograph: Reuters

War in Iran spells major trouble for Turkey

Deepening conflict in the Middle East raises the prospect of renewed inflation. That could spell big trouble for Turkey's economy in particular. The spike in energy prices and potential disruptions to supplies from Iran—which accounts for roughly 14% of Turkey's gas imports—threaten to deliver a body blow. Thanks to high interest rates, inflation has been falling from a peak of over 80% in 2022. Data released Tuesday showed annual inflation at 31.5%, a slight increase on the previous month's figures. Chaos in Iran may push prices up further. Turkish markets are already feeling the shock.

Other risks loom. A prolonged war could push hundreds of thousands of refugees towards Turkey, which shares a 534km border with Iran. A civil war in Iran would make matters even worse. A Kurdish uprising in Iran could also upend Turkey's peace talks with its own Kurdish insurgents. The country has every right to be extremely nervous.

Photograph: Reuters

Britain’s chancellor plays it safe

On Tuesday the Office for Budget Responsibility publishes its outlook for the British economy and public finances. Rachel Reeves will respond to the independent forecaster’s findings in Parliament, but not much more. After last November’s chaotic budget, the chancellor wants this event to be as boring as possible. She is likely to make few, if any, policy announcements, though she will probably talk about the conflict in Iran, if only to reassure markets that Britain has a plan for dealing with its economic consequences.

The OBR’s numbers are expected to look broadly similar to those in the budget, though expected debt costs may be a bit lower. The real story, though, may be what the OBR won’t yet account for: sharply lower migration projections, which will constrain economic growth, and mounting pressure on the government to raise defence spending. Watch for any hints the OBR drops on these issues. They could make the budget next autumn less boring than Ms Reeves would like.

Photograph: Reuters

Democrats hope to flip a Senate seat in Texas

On Tuesday Texans will choose Senate nominees in primaries that could shape who controls Congress come November's midterms. Democrats sniff a chance of flipping a seat in America's biggest red state for the first time since 1988.

Republicans must pick between John Cornyn, a four-term incumbent who calls himself a "work-horse" and sometimes dares to work with Democrats, and Ken Paxton, the combative attorney-general who boasts of suing Joe Biden 107 times. Mr Paxton also has his own legal troubles, which he casts as a Trump-style witch-hunt. Polls are tight; a run-off favouring Mr Paxton looks likely.

Democrats face their own electability test. Jasmine Crockett, a sharp-tongued congresswoman (pictured right), delights activists by hurling viral insults at Republicans online. James Talarico, a 36-year-old former teacher and seminarian (pictured left), offers a calmer populism that appeals even to conservatives. If he wins and faces Mr Paxton, national Democrats will flood Texas with cash. To control the Senate, the party has to win red-leaning states.

Photograph: Getty Images

A nuanced take on Japan’s notorious wartime leader

Biographies of second world war leaders, such as Winston Churchill and Adolf Hitler, are reliable sellers for publishers. But Tojo Hideki, Japan’s prime minister between 1941 and 1944, has for decades been left off English readers’ shelves. Peter Mauch, an Australian historian, has now written “Tojo: The Rise and Fall of Japan’s Most Controversial World War II General”, which is published in America on Tuesday.

Tojo stood trial in front of the Tokyo war-crimes tribunal after Japan’s defeat, and was hanged in 1948. To most Japanese, his bald, bespectacled and moustached face lingers as a symbol of evil. Meanwhile, a nationalist, right-wing fringe has sought to lionise him.

Drawing on newly available sources, including Tojo’s writings and the diaries of his secretaries, Mr Mauch portrays him as “neither hero nor villain”. He delves into the complexities of his life, and shows how absolute loyalty to the emperor and a peerless ability to “navigate and manipulate the complex administrative structures of army and state” drove Japan to ruin.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Which book by Nate Silver, published in 2012, is about the art of interpreting statistics?

Monday: Which British newspaper, when owned by Lord Beaverbrook, had the largest circulation in the world in the 1940s?

You cannot force ideas. Successful ideas are the result of slow growth.

Alexander Graham Bell